

Game Components and Overview

As spring dawns, the great thaw begins. Deep beneath the lush meadow grass, the queen stirs in her nest and the colony comes to life. Soldiers venture forth, battling centipedes and clashing with opposing colonies for territory. Workers dig an ever-expanding network of tunnels in their tireless search for food. The first larvae hatch, and it is clear this generation will be different: the young ants rapidly evolve into a multitude of new forms. The ants march out to claim the meadow as their own.

GAME OVERVIEW

March of the Ants is a civilization game where each player grows an ant colony. You will explore the meadow, gather resources, evolve a unique ant species, and march to battle.

There are many different paths to victory. Throughout the game you will gain Colony Points by expanding your territory, evolving your ants, meeting colony goals, and battling. At the end of the game, the player with the most points will rule the Meadow!

March of the Ants is played over several rounds, each of which has 4 distinct phases:

- **Worker Phase**, where you take turns taking actions.
- **Soldier Phase**, where battles are fought in contested locations.
- **Queen Phase**, where you harvest resources and feed your ants.
- **Slumber**, where you score points for your achievements during the round.

1 Great Tunnel



13 Standard Hexes (#11-23)



10 Starting Hexes (#1-10)



5 Beyond the Meadow Hexes (#24 - 28)



13 Rest Tiles



1 Active Player Marker



5 Nest Mats



5 Score Markers (+50)
6 Strength Markers (+10)



30 Food Tokens



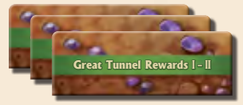
180 Wooden Ants
(36 in each player color)



66 Ant Cards



6 Reward Tiles



1 Score/Round Track



1 Round Marker



6 Centipede Tokens
& 1 Centipede Size Marker



12 Wormhole / Extra Centipede Tokens



5 Quick References



1 Solo/Co-op Mat
and 1 Rules Sheet



1 Strength Track



CREDITS AND THANKS!

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Ant, Larva, or Egg?

The wooden ant tokens represent different stages of the life cycle of ants, depending on where they are located. When tokens are in the Meadow (the Great Tunnel or hexes), they are **ants**. When they are in your Larvae Chamber, they are **larvae**. All other tokens are kept to the side of the Nest Mat as **eggs**.

GAIN LARVA – Take an egg from your supply and place it in your Larvae Chamber.

MOVE LARVA – Take a larva from your Larvae Chamber and place it into the Meadow, where it immediately becomes an ant.



LIMITED ANTS – Each player has a limit of 36 wooden ant tokens available to them each game. If they are all in use, the player cannot gain more larva or ants. We've included a few extras in the game to cover any manufacturing issues. Please set aside any extras to use as backup.

How To Use This Book

Concept Sections

Sections labeled as Concepts contain important rules, but you don't need to read them in full before moving on. Instead, you can consult them as you encounter the actions that refer to them.

Notes

Text in green italics are notes and clarifications about how the rules work. *This is an example note.*

Cards and Rules Clarifications

March of the Ants is a game about evolving your ants with abilities that change the way you get to play the game, and sometimes break the rules. Pages 22 and 23 address questions we think could come up about the interaction of certain cards and abilities.

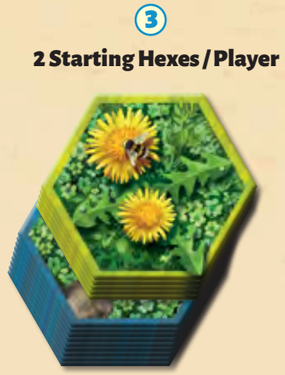
How to Play Video

Skip the rulebook and watch a how to play video. Scan the QR code or visit weirdcitygames.com/pages/learn-to-play-mota

3-5 Player Setup

Game Setup

1. Place the Great Tunnel in the center of the table.
2. Place the Score/Round Track on one side of the play area on the 4-round side and place the Strength Track beneath it. Place the Round Marker on Round 1 and the Centipede Size Marker on the space corresponding to the player count.
3. Shuffle the starting hexes (#1-10) together and place 2 per player to form a facedown stack. Return the rest to the game box.
4. Randomly select 2* Beyond the Meadow hexes (#24-28) and shuffle them with the **standard** hexes (#11-23). Place the starting hex stack from step 3 on top of these, and place the combined stack near the Great Tunnel.
   **With 4-5 players, add 1 extra Beyond the Meadow hex.*
5. Place the food, centipede, and wormhole tokens next to the play area.
6. Place the Great Defender Rest Tile beneath the Round Track. Shuffle the other Rest Tiles and place them in a facedown stack nearby. Draw and place tiles faceup under the Score Track until there is 1 Rest Tile per player.
7. Randomly select 2 Reward Tiles from each level. Place the two "I - II" tiles on top of the two "III+" tiles to form a facedown stack. Return the rest to the box.
8. Reveal the top Reward Tile and place it faceup in the center of the Great Tunnel.
9. Randomly select a starting player and give them the Active Player Marker.
10. Shuffle the Ant Card deck. Place it near the play area.



3
2 Starting Hexes / Player

4
Standard Hexes &
2 -3 Beyond the Meadow Hexes

5

Food Tokens

Wormhole Tokens

Centipede Tokens



1

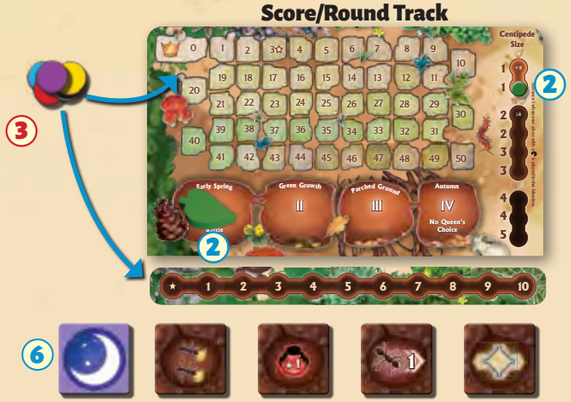
7 **Reward Tiles**



9



Score/Round Track



Great Defender Rest Tile

10

Ant Cards



Game Variants

2 Player

See page 20 for special setup and gameplay rules.

Advanced Variants

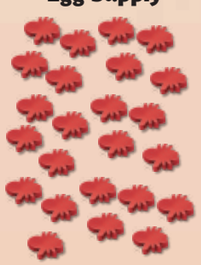
The Epic (5-round) game and asymmetric ancient species rules are on page 21.

Solo/Co-op

The rules for the solo and co-op are explained on the standalone *Rise of the Centipedes* sheet.

2
Ants

2
Egg Supply



Larvae

Food



3
Score and Strength Markers



5

1
Star

Player Setup (each player)

1. Choose a color. Take 36 ant tokens of that color and 1 Nest Mat with the ☆ side up.
2. Place 4 of your ant tokens into your Larvae Chamber as larvae and 2 in the Great Tunnel as ants. Place the rest on the side of your Nest Mat as eggs.
3. Place your Score and Strength Markers on the ☆ spaces of their respective tracks, with the printed sides down.
4. Place 2 food tokens into your Food Stores.
5. Draw 3 cards.

   Advanced Variant: Each player draws 2 cards, plus their number in the player order (e.g. the 3rd player draws 5 cards). Each player selects 3 cards to keep. Shuffle and place the rest on bottom of the deck.

The Worker Phase

Overview

During the Worker Phase, players take turns in clockwise order, starting with the player with the Active Player Marker. Play continues until all faceup Rest Tiles have been taken using the Rest action.

At the end of the Worker Phase, each player with an evolved thorax will get to take one or more bonus reactions.

Taking a Turn

On your turn, choose an action to perform.

ACTION – Explore, Forage, March, Play a Card, or Rest. You first pay the cost, then perform the action.

REACTIONS – After you take an action, the 2 neighboring players may take the associated reaction. Reactions have no cost and are taken in clockwise order from the Active Player. *The player to your left goes first, then the player to the right.*

After your action and the reactions are resolved, pass the Active Player Marker clockwise, and the next turn begins.



Worker Phase Actions

There are 5 Worker Phase actions that you may choose from on your turn. On the following pages, you'll find each of these explained in detail.

EXPLORE – Add a new hex to the Meadow, and move ants from adjacent connected locations to it.
Reaction: Move a larva into the Meadow.

FORAGE – Draw 3 cards, then discard a card from your hand.
Reaction: Gain a larva.

MARCH – Move your larvae to the Meadow and your ants around the Meadow using steps.
Reaction: Take 1 ant step or move a larva to the Great Tunnel.

PLAY A CARD – Pay the cost for a card in your hand to play it.
Reaction: Discard a card from your hand to draw a new card.

REST – Conclude your other actions for the round and begin taking Rest Tiles. *You may not Rest on your first turn in a round.*
Reaction: None.

Concepts: Hex Rules

Placing a Hex

Anytime you place a hex in the Meadow, whether through Exploration, a card effect, or another ability:

- You must connect at least one of its tunnel openings to an existing tunnel opening.
- You may block its tunnels or the tunnels of other hexes.

If the hex has a feature (wormhole or centipede) place the corresponding token on the hex. Resolve any special abilities.

Inhabiting a Hex

When you have at least one ant in a collection site in a hex, you **inhabit** that hex. Inhabiting a hex allows you to move larvae directly to that hex when moving larvae, and is required for many card effects and abilities.

Movement and Hexes

When you move an ant into a hex, it immediately **inhabits** an empty collection site of your choice. If none are empty, place the ant in the **outskirts** (anywhere else on that hex).

When an ant leaves a collection site, any ant in the **outskirts** of that hex will immediately inhabit it at the end of the current action or reaction.

If multiple players have ants in the outskirts, players take turns inhabiting as many of the empty sites as they can in player order.

Sharing & Contesting Hexes

Ants from multiple colonies may peacefully share a hex as long as there are enough collection sites for all the ants. A hex is **shared** when 2 or more players' ants **inhabit** that hex.

If a hex is shared, but there are not enough sites for all the ants, that hex is also **contested**. During the Soldier Phase, there will be a battle in each contested hex.

Concepts: Guide to the Meadow

The Meadow is the game board where most of the action takes place in March of the Ants. It is made up of distinct **locations**, which include the Great Tunnel and all placed hexes. It will expand during the game as you Explore and place new hexes.



The Great Tunnel

The Great Tunnel is the center of the Meadow and the origin of all of the ant colonies. A battle will take place here during the Soldier Phase if multiple players' ants are present.

GREAT TUNNEL RULES –

- The Great Tunnel does not count as a hex.
- Hexes adjacent to the Great Tunnel grant 1 to their controller during Slumber.
- When moving larvae, players may always move them to the Great Tunnel.



Hexes

Hexes have different features, collection sites, and sometimes special rules. Ants in a hex will first inhabit **collection sites** but if all sites are full may reside in the **outskirts**.

COLLECTION SITE – Offers valuable resources that ants may collect during the Queen Phase. Each site may be **inhabited** by at most one ant.

CONTROL SITE – A type of collection site that also grants control of the hex. Control of a hex is important for scoring, and during battle.

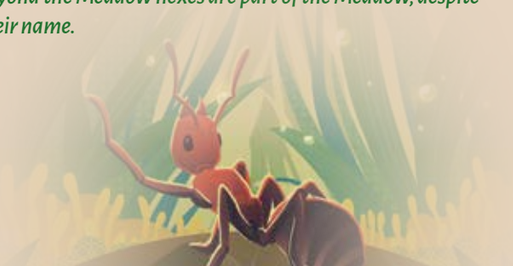
OUTSKIRTS – Anywhere in the hex that is not a site. Ants may occupy the outskirts of a hex only if there are no empty collection sites in that hex. They do not **inhabit** the hex or harvest resources, but do participate in battle.

NAME AND NUMBER – Hex numbers are used in the Soldier Phase, and are color-coded according to their number. Hex names do not have any gameplay effect.

TUNNELS – Ants may move between adjacent locations if those locations have a connected tunnel.

BEYOND THE MEADOW EFFECTS – Beyond the Meadow hexes have unique effects. Each has its special effect written on it. The player who places the hex resolves any "when placed" effects before any players take reactions.

Beyond the Meadow hexes are part of the Meadow, despite their name.





CENTIPEDES ( ) – Place a centipede token on the hex. Advance the Centipede Size by 1.
To advance the Centipede Size, move the Centipede Size Marker down one space.

Centipedes are threats to the ants. Ants may move into hexes with centipedes and inhabit collection sites as normal, but will have to battle the centipedes during the Soldier Phase.

WORMHOLES ( ) – Place a wormhole token on the hex. Ants may move between 2 hexes that have wormholes with a single step.

Wormholes do not connect hexes for the purposes of card effects and exploration.

Actions & Reactions

Actions are detailed here, and are shown in icon form on each player's nest mat.

Action Diagram



1. The cost that must be paid before taking the action.
2. The action you take.
3. The reaction each neighboring player may take.

Explore — *Cost: 1 food*

ACTION: Draw a hex and place it connected by a tunnel to an adjacent location where you have at least 1 ant. *Draw the hex first, then choose where to place it. For full hex placement rules see page 6.*

Move any number of your ants from any adjacent connected locations into the explored hex. **You must move at least 1 ant.**
Ants will immediately move into collection sites, or to the outskirts if all sites are full.

REACTIONS: Each **neighbor** may move 1 larva from their Larvae Chamber to a hex they **inhabit** or to the Great Tunnel.
You inhabit any hex where you have an ant in a collection site. When a larva enters the Meadow it becomes an ant.

Explore Example

1. Blue chooses to take the Explore action. They pay 1 food and draw the top hex (Underleaf). They choose to place it with tunnels connected to Fungal Reach and Stoney Mound.
2. Blue must move at least 1 ant from a connected location into the newly explored hex. They choose to move 1 ant from Fungal Reach and 1 from Stoney Mound. Those ants immediately inhabit the collection sites in Underleaf.
3. Red is the player to Blue's left, so takes the first reaction to Blue's Explore action. They place a larva from their Larvae Chamber into Stoney Mound, where it immediately inhabits the card collection site that Blue vacated.
4. Yellow is the player to Blue's right, so takes the next reaction. They do not inhabit any hexes, so they place a larva from their Larvae Chamber into the Great Tunnel.



Forage — *Cost: 1 food*

ACTION: Draw 3 cards, then discard any 1 card from your hand. *There is no limit to hand size.*

REACTION: Each **neighbor** may gain 1 larva.

To gain a larva, move an egg from your supply to your Larvae Chamber. If you have no eggs in your supply, you may not gain a larva.

If at any time you would draw a card and there are none left in the deck, shuffle the discard pile to make a new deck. Then draw from the new deck.

March — *Cost: 1 food*

ACTION: Take 6 steps with your larvae and/or ants.

REACTION: Each **neighbor** may take 1 **ant step**, or move 1 larva from their Larvae Chamber to the Great Tunnel.

Taking steps is always optional. When you March you may take any number of steps up to 6.

Concepts: Steps

Steps let you move ants around the Meadow and move larvae into the Meadow, where they become ants. Taking steps is always optional.

One step allows you to move:

- 1 ant from any location to any adjacent connected location.
- 1 ant from a location with a wormhole to any other location with a wormhole.
- 1 ant from a collection site to another open collection site in the same hex.
- 1 larva from your Larvae Chamber to any hex that you **inhabit** or the Great Tunnel.

ANT STEP – Abilities that instruct you to take ant steps only allow you to move ants, not larvae.

You may use multiple steps to move 1 ant several times, or distribute them among several ants or larvae.

Play a Card — *Cost: Shown on Card*

ACTION: Play one card from your hand.

REACTION: Each **neighbor** may discard a card from their hand to draw a card.

Playing a card does not cost food. To pay for a card, remove **larvae and/or ants** equal to the cost of the card from your Larvae Chamber or the Meadow and return them to your supply of eggs.


Pay with any combination of larvae from your Larvae Chamber and ants from the Meadow.


Pay only with ants from the Meadow.


Pay only with larvae from your Larvae Chamber.

The card types, their different uses, and their effects are explained on pages 12 and 13.

Rest — *Cost: None*

You may not Rest as your first action of a round, unless you have no food and no cards in hand.

ACTION: Take 1 Rest Tile of your choice from the faceup Rest Tiles for the round and gain its rewards. You may only take the Rest action on subsequent turns.

REACTION: None.

Rest is a special action, taken when you are finished taking other actions for the round. Once you have Rested, you must Rest on each subsequent turn.

Each time you Rest, choose an available Rest Tile and place it next to your Nest Mat. Some Rest Tiles will grant immediate rewards, while some grant bonuses or effects later in the round. A reference to each can be found on the back cover of these rules.

When a player takes the last faceup Rest tile, they finish their turn, pass the Active Player Marker clockwise, and the Worker Phase ends. (See the following page for end of Worker Phase effects.)

The player with the Active Player Marker keeps it for the rest of the round, and will go first in the next Worker Phase.

End of the Worker Phase

At the end of the Worker Phase, in player order starting with the Active Player, take reactions equal to the number of thorax Evolutions you have in play.

- You may not choose the same reaction twice.
- Each player takes all of their reactions before the next player takes any of theirs.
- Choose reactions from the four standard actions: Explore, Forage, March, or Play a Card.

For example, Red has evolved their thorax twice, and Blue once. The Worker Phase ends and Red becomes the active player. Red chooses to gain a larva and to take 1 ant step. Blue then chooses to gain a larva. Yellow has no evolved thoraxes, so takes no reactions.

If you have more than 4 evolved thoraxes, you only take 4 reactions—one of each.

After all thorax reactions have been resolved, the Soldier Phase begins. (The Soldier Phase rules start on page 14).

Concepts: Great Tunnel Defender

The Great Defender Rest Tile is available each round. It grants the player who has it the status of defender in the Great Tunnel. Being the defender provides benefits in battle: the defender wins ties, and has the opportunity to act last. (See page 14 for more details.)



Occasionally a player will take the Great Defender tile but will not be involved in the Great Tunnel Battle. In this sad case, they are still the defender for the purposes of determining the order of playing cards and breaking ties in the Great Tunnel, even though they do not participate in the battle.



March Example



1. Red wants to move larvae into Dung, but cannot move them directly since Red's ants do not inhabit any collection sites in Dung.
2. Red pays 1 food to March, and may take up to 6 steps. Red uses 3 steps to move 3 larvae into the outskirts of Stoney Mound (The larvae become ants upon entering the Meadow.)
3. Red uses their fourth step to move an ant from Stoney Mound into the available larva collection site in Dung.
4. Red now inhabits Dung, and uses 1 step to move a larva into the other available collection site in that hex. They choose to forego their final step.
5. There are no available sites in Stoney Mound, so the 2 red ants remain in the outskirts. Stoney Mound is now a contested hex because there are ants from 2 players and ants in the outskirts. If it is still contested during the Soldier Phase, a battle will occur.

March Reaction Example



Continuing from the previous example:

1. Yellow and Blue are Red's neighbors, so they each get a reaction to Red's March action. Yellow is the first player in clockwise order from Red, so they take the first reaction, moving an ant 1 step from Stoney Mound into Dry Seep.
2. A red ant in the outskirts of Stoney Mound immediately inhabits the vacated collection site. This happens automatically without requiring a step (see Movement and Hexes on page 6).
3. Blue also gets a reaction and moves into the outskirts of Dry Seep, making it contested.

   Unlike in step 2, the red ants in Stoney Mound do not automatically move to the vacated collection site, since they are not in the outskirts. Red will need to use a step on a future turn to move an ant from one collection site to another.

Types of Ant Cards

EVENTS

Event Cards are one-time effects that represent the actions of ants or natural forces. After an Event card is resolved, place it faceup in the discard pile.



1. **COST TYPE** – The resource(s) that must be paid. *Sparrow Attack* may only be paid for with 2 larvae.
2. **COST** – The amount that must be paid.
3. **CARD NAME** – No gameplay effect.
4. **FEROCITY** ( ) – The number of dots represents the card's strength if used in battle (see page 15).
5. **CARD TYPE** – Detailed on this page.
6. **CARD TEXT** – Describes effects and abilities.
7. **SOLO SYMBOL** – Indicates that the card is used to create a separate deck in Solo/ Co-op Games. (See the *Rise of the Centipedes* rulesheet).

COLONY GOALS

Colony Goals provide unique objectives to score **each Slumber** and give bonus effects when played. When you play a Colony Goal card, place it faceup on the right side of your Nest Mat.



1. **COST TYPE** – The card shown above may be paid for with 2 ants, 2 larvae, or 1 of each.
2. **GOAL REMINDER ICON** – A small visual to remind you what the goal wants you to do.
3. **GOAL REWARD LEVELS** – Each Slumber, gain points equal to level of completion.
4. **IMMEDIATE EFFECT** – Resolve when played.
5. **GOAL TEXT** – The scoring condition evaluated in Slumber.

GOAL LIMIT – You may have a maximum of 2 Colony Goal cards in play. If you play another Colony Goal, you must first discard one that you have in play.

Scoring a Colony Goal Example

Each Slumber, gain for how well the objective is met.

For example, to score Clever Innovators (shown above), count up the number of card collection sites you inhabit and take only the reward for the level you are on.

- 0-1 sites: No points.
- Exactly 2 sites: 1.
- 3 or 4 sites: 2.
- 5 or more: 3.

EVOLUTIONS

Evolutions are played to the Head, Thorax, and Abdomen segments of your ant body on your Nest Mat, granting your ants a unique ability and a bonus. Thoraxes affect the Worker Phase, heads affect the Soldier Phase, and abdomens affect the Queen Phase.



1. **COST TYPE** – This card's cost may be paid only with ants.
2. **SCIENTIFIC NAME** – No gameplay effect.
3. **BODY SEGMENT SYMBOL** –
4. **FLAVOR TEXT** – A fun fact about ants.

When you play an Evolution, place it on top of all other Evolutions in that body segment. Only the **topmost** Evolution in each body segment grants a unique ability, but all Evolutions will add to their **segment bonus**.

SEGMENT BONUSES – Each body segment (head, thorax, and abdomen) grants a bonus based on the number of Evolution cards you have in play in that body segment.

Head ( ): In battle, gain +1 Strength for each head Evolution you have.

Thorax ( ): At the end of the Worker Phase, for each thorax Evolution you have, choose 1 different **reaction** from the four standard actions: Explore, Forage, March, or Play a Card.

Abdomen ( ): Your food feeds 1 additional ant during the Queen Phase for each abdomen Evolution you have.

EVOLUTION ABILITY TIMING – When multiple abilities would happen at the same time, each player, starting with the Active Player, resolves all of their abilities in the order of their choosing before moving on to the next player in clockwise order.

An evolution cannot affect its own play. For instance, the Garden Thorax cannot reduce its own cost.

FULLY EVOLVED ANT BODY – Immediately gain 3 when you complete an ant body. A complete body has a head, a thorax, and an abdomen. You may complete and score multiple ant bodies, but each card may only be used to score one ant body.

Evolution Example

1. Red has 2 head Evolutions in play, so they gain the head segment bonus twice. Red will add 2 Strength in each battle they fight. Red gains the ability from the Armored Head, but not from the Evolution played below it.
2. Red has 1 thorax Evolution in play. They gain the ability from the Scouting Thorax. They also gain the thorax segment bonus, letting them take 1 reaction of their choice at the end of the Worker Phase.
3. Red does not have an abdomen Evolution in play. They do not have an abdomen segment bonus when feeding ants.
4. If Red plays an abdomen Evolution, they will immediately gain 3 for completing an ant body.



The Soldier Phase

SOLDIER PHASE STEPS:

1. In the Great Tunnel, resolve battle if 2 or more players' ants are present. If only 1 player's ants are present, they gain the 1st-place award and no battle occurs.
2. Resolve battles in contested hexes in ascending order of hex number. *No hex battles occur in Round 1. Skip this step.*
3. After all battles are resolved, the Soldier Phase ends and the Queen Phase begins.

Contested Hexes

A hex is contested when there are 2 or more players' ants in the hex **and** there are ants in the outskirts, or if there is a centipede in a hex containing any ants.

If a contested hex becomes uncontested before a battle starts there, the battle will not occur.

Great Tunnel Battle Example

The Red, Black, Blue, and Yellow players all have ants in the Great Tunnel and follow these steps to resolve the battle.

(1) **DETERMINE DEFENDER** – Red took the Great Defender Rest Tile, so they are the defender in the Great Tunnel.

(2) **DECLARE STRENGTH** – ( ) Red has 1 ant for a Strength of 1. Blue has 2 ants for a Strength of 2. Black has 4 ants for a Strength of 4. Yellow has 2 ants and 1 head Evolution for a Strength of 3. Each player adjusts their marker on the Strength Track to show their current Strength.

(3) **FEROCITY** – Red is the defender, so the player on their left (Blue) chooses to play a card facedown for Ferocity first. Yellow is next in player order and also plays a card. Black then decides to play a card as well. Finally, Red chooses not to play a card.

(4) **FEROCITY REVEAL** – Blue reveals their card with a of 2. Yellow reveals their card with a of 1. Black reveals their card with a of 2. They each add these to their Strength and adjust their Strength Marker.

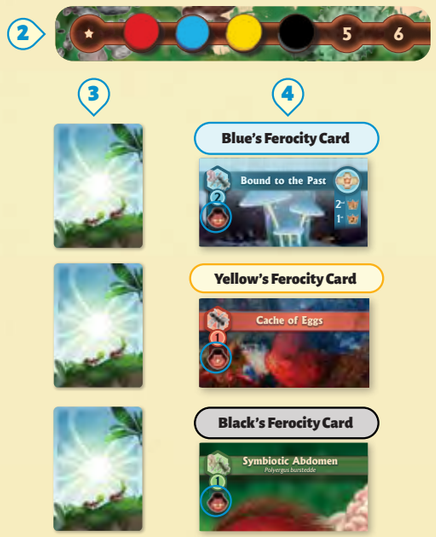
(5) **OUTCOME** – Black wins with a Strength of 6. Blue and Yellow are tied with a Strength of 4. Blue wins the tie for 2nd place because they are first from the defender (Red) in clockwise order. Red has 1 Strength.

(6) **CASUALTIES** – Black wins, so all other players lose. Red, Yellow, and Blue have a combined total of 5 ants, so they assign 2 casualties to Black.

Black assigns 4 casualties, distributing them as evenly as possible in clockwise order: 1 to Red, Blue, and Yellow, and then 1 more to Blue (Red has already been assigned enough casualties to remove all their ants).

Each player then loses 1 ant for each casualty they were assigned, returning them to their egg supply.

(7) **SPOILS** – Black gains the 1st-place reward of . Blue gains the 2nd place reward of (despite losing all of their ants). Yellow gains the 3rd place reward of . Red is in 4th place, so they do not gain a reward.





Ant Battle

Ant battle is fought between all players with ants in a contested location. Only one **ant battle** occurs in each location during the Soldier Phase, even if the location is still contested after battle.

The Contest: Strength, Ferocity and Outcome

1. Determine Defender

In hexes, the player who inhabits the control site is the defender. In the Great Tunnel, it is the player with the Great Defender Rest Tile.

2. Declare Strength

Each player counts their ants in the hex, and adds the number of head Evolutions they have. They set their marker to that number on the Strength Track.

+

3. Ferocity

Starting with the player to the left of the defender and proceeding clockwise, each player in the battle may play 1 card from their hand facedown.

REVEAL FEROCITY – All players reveal their cards and add the number of pips shown in the symbol to their Strength, adjusting their position on the Strength Track.

4. Outcome

The player with the greatest Strength is the winner. In the Great Tunnel, also determine 2nd and 3rd place based on Strength.

Ties: Starting with the defender, ties are won in clockwise order.

Only one player can win. The other players, including the 2nd and 3rd place players, lose.



The Results: Spoils and Casualties

5. Casualties

Players assign casualties to each other, and then lose ants.

Losing Players: For every 2 ants, assign 1 casualty to the winner. Count all losing players' ants together.

→

Winning Player: For each ant, assign 1 casualty, distributed as evenly as possible to losing players in clockwise order from the winner.

→

CASUALTY RULES –

- **Lone Survivor:** The winner cannot lose their last ant in the location.
- Each player may only be assigned enough casualties to remove all of their ants.
  For instance, if a player has 3 ants, plus the Armored Head (which prevents one casualty) they may be assigned 4 casualties maximum.

Once all casualties have been assigned, each player loses 1 ant of their choice from the battle location for each casualty they were assigned.

6. Spoils

Players collect their spoils:

Hexes: The winner gains and may move 1 ant in the hex into the control site, pushing any occupant to the outskirts.

The Great Tunnel: 1st, 2nd, and 3rd place players gain the spoils shown on the reward tile.



Players gain spoils even if all their ants were removed during Casualties.

After Battle

7. Cleanup

Players take turns moving **all** of their ants in the outskirts of that hex to vacant collection sites in clockwise order starting with the winner. Reset the markers on the Strength Track to zero. Discard all cards played during battle.

Centipede Battle

Hexes containing a centipede and any ants are contested. Centipede battles follow the ant battle rules with these exceptions:

1. Determine Defender

The centipede battles players in the hex one at a time starting with the player with the **most ants** in the hex. *Resolve ties clockwise starting with the hex's controller, or the active player if no ant is in the control site.*

The player battling the centipede is the defender.

2. Declare Strength

The centipede's starting Strength is shown on the Centipede Size Track. Place the Centipede Strength Marker on that space of the Strength Track at the start of battle.

3. Ferocity

After the player's Ferocity step, draw and reveal a card from the Ant Deck and advance the centipede's Strength equal to the value of the revealed card.

Unpredictable Foe: If any card drawn for the centipede has a (1 Ferocity), advance the centipede's Strength Marker on the Strength Track by 1, then draw and resolve another card.

4. Outcome

If the player's Strength is equal or greater than the centipede's, they win.

5. Casualties

Player wins: Remove the centipede and take casualties equal to half your ants in the hex, rounded up.

Centipede wins: Take casualties equal to all of your ants in the hex. *These casualties cannot be prevented.*

6. Spoils

If the player won, they gain the reward indicated on the Centipede Size Track and may move 1 ant into the control site, pushing any occupant to the outskirts.

7. Cleanup

- Discard all cards drawn by the centipede.
- If the centipede wins, it will start a new battle if there are still ants in the hex.
- If the centipede is defeated and the hex is still contested, the ants in that hex will battle.

The Centipede Size Track

The Centipede Size Track shows the base strength of all centipedes in the Meadow, as well as bonuses for defeating them.

1. The Strength is indicated by the number to the left of the marker.
2. Whenever a hex with a centipede icon () is placed, advance the marker one space. *Other effects may also instruct you to advance the Centipede Size.*
3. When the marker advances past a break in the track to a new section, the Spoils for defeating centipedes becomes more valuable. Take only the Spoils shown at the top of the section the marker is in.

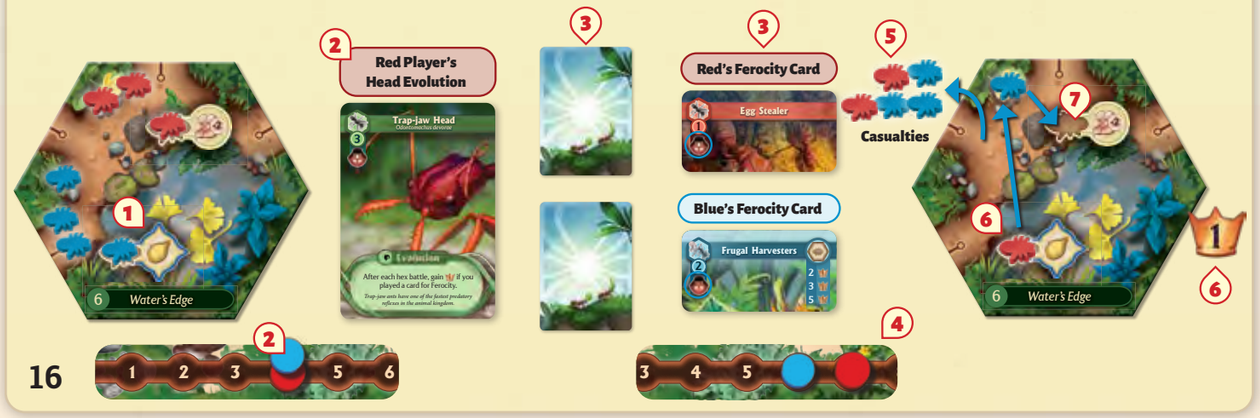


Ant Battle In A Hex Example

CONTESTED HEX – Water's Edge is contested (there are multiple players' ants present and ants in the outskirts).

1. **DETERMINE DEFENDER** – Blue is the defender because they inhabit the control site.
2. **DECLARE STRENGTH** – Red has 3 ants and 1 head for a Strength of 4. Blue has 4 ants and no heads, so declares 4 Strength. Each player adjusts their marker on the Strength Track to show their current Strength.
3. **FEROCITY** – Red is not the defender, so must decide whether they want to play a card for Ferocity first. They choose to play a card, placing it facedown in front of them. After Red chooses, Blue also chooses to play a card.

   FEROCITY REVEAL – Red reveals their card; it has a of 3. Blue reveals their card; it has a of 2.
4. **OUTCOME** – Blue's total Strength is 6. Red wins with a total of 7 Strength.
5. **CASUALTIES** – Blue lost, so their 4 ants deal 2 casualties to Red. Red won so their 3 ants deal 3 casualties to Blue. Red chooses to lose one of their ants in the outskirts and one from the 2-larvae collection site. Blue loses 3 ants from the outskirts.
6. **SPOILS** – Red gains 1 and moves an ant into the control site, pushing the blue ant to the outskirts.
7. **CLEANUP** – There is an open site, so the Blue ant moves into it. Red gains an additional 1 from their Trap-jaw Head, since they played a card for Ferocity.



Centipede Battle Example

1. The Bark hex has a centipede and ants, so it is contested.
2. Red has more ants in the hex than Yellow, so they battle the centipede first. They have 4 Strength.
3. The Centipede Size is 2, so the Centipede Strength Marker is placed on the Strength Track on 2.
4. Red plays a card, adding its of 2 for a total of 6 Strength.
5. The centipede draws and reveals the top card of the deck, adding the of 1 to its Strength on the Strength Track. Because it drew a card with a of 1, it draws again.
6. The centipede's second card has a of 4, for a total of 7. The centipede wins, so all of the Red ants are lost.



1. Yellow moves their 2 ants from the outskirts into the newly empty collection sites, and must now battle the centipede.
2. The centipede's Strength is reset to 2.
3. Yellow plays a card with a of 4, for a total Strength of 7.
4. The centipede draws card with a of 3 for a total of 5 Strength.
5. Yellow wins, the centipede is defeated, and its token is returned to the supply. Yellow loses half of their total ants rounded up (2). Yellow gains 1 food and 1 based on the position of the Centipede Size Marker.



The Queen Phase

During the Queen Phase, you Harvest, Feed Ants, and then make your Queen's Choice.

Harvest

Gain resources from collection sites that your ants inhabit.

- Add 1 food to your stores.
- Add 1 or 2 larvae to your Larvae Chamber (as shown on the collection site).
- Draw a card.
- Advance your Score Marker 1 space.

To help correctly collect your harvest, we recommend counting each type of resource separately.

Feed Ants

All ants in the Meadow need to be fed to survive. Larvae do not need to be fed. Each food can feed up to 4 ants, plus 1 ant for each abdomen Evolution you have.

If you have one abdomen Evolution, you would be able to feed 5 ants with 1 food, up to 10 ants with 2 food, and so on.

You may choose not to feed any number of your ants, but you will lose any ants you do not feed, returning them to your egg supply.

Starvation: If you fail to feed **one or more** ants, you lose 1 (total, not per ant).

Additionally, if you fail to feed any ants in Autumn you will not be eligible for endgame awards.

Queen's Choice

After all ants have been fed, you decide if your queen will produce food, larvae, or a mix of both to prepare the colony for the next round.

Each player chooses **twice** to gain 1 food or 3 larvae.

There is no Queen's Choice in the final round.

If needed, resolve the Queen's Choice in clockwise order starting with the active player.

Slumber

During Slumber, you score points and refresh the board for the next round.

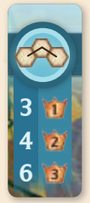
Score Inner Meadow Hexes

Gain 1 for each Inner Meadow hex you control. All hexes that are **adjacent** to the Great Tunnel are part of the Inner Meadow. They do not need to be **connected** to the Great Tunnel to score.



Score Colony Goals

You can gain 1, 2, or 3 points for meeting the conditions of the Colony Goal cards you have in play. The number of points you gain is based on how well you meet the condition, as shown on the card. (See page 12 for more details.)



Prepare For The Next Round

If it is the final round, the game ends. Otherwise, advance the Round Marker one space and complete the following steps to prepare for the next round:

1. Return the Great Defender Rest Tile to the area beneath the Round Track.
2. Discard all other Rest Tiles in a faceup discard stack. Reveal new Rest Tiles until there is 1 tile per player beneath the Round Track.

   If all Rest Tiles have been used, shuffle all discarded Rest Tiles to form a new stack.
3. Discard the current Reward Tile. Reveal the topmost Reward Tile and place it faceup in the Great Tunnel.
4. The next Worker Phase begins.

The player who was passed the Active Player Marker at the end of the last Worker Phase takes the first turn.

Example Queen Phase and Slumber

Queen Phase

Harvest

Red collects 2 food, 3 larvae, 1 card, and 1.

Blue collects 1 food, 2 larvae, and 1.

Black collects 2 food and 5 larvae.

Feed Ants

Red's 6 ants will need to eat 2 food.

Blue's 4 ants will need to eat 1 food.

Black has a total of 9 ants, which normally would require 3 food. However, Black has an abdomen Evolution in play, so each food they use will feed 1 additional ant. Black's ants only need to eat 2 food.

Queen's Choice

Each player chooses two times whether to gain 1 food or 3 larvae.

Blue chooses to gain 2 food, Red chooses to gain 6 larvae, and Black chooses to gain 1 food and 3 larvae.

Slumber

Inner Meadow Points

Red controls Dry Seep and Soil and gains 2. Red also controls Bark, but it is not adjacent to the Great Tunnel so they gain no Inner Meadow points for it.

Black controls Tall Sand and Water's Edge and gains 2.

Blue controls Loamy Tunnels and gains 1.

Colony Goal Points

Red gains 1 for meeting the topmost condition of Extensive Tunnel by controlling 3 hexes connected by a single tunnel (Soil, Bark, and Dry Seep).





Game End and Victory

After the final round, determine the winner of each endgame award and declare a winner!

ENDGAME AWARDS – Compare resources for endgame awards. Each award grants 2 to the player who wins it. If players tie for an award, each tied player gains 1.

Players who failed to feed any of their ants in Autumn are ineligible for endgame awards. If they would win an award, it goes to the player with the next most.

The awards go to the player who has:

LARGEST BROOD – The most larvae.

GREATEST STORES – The most food.

UNTOLD POTENTIAL – The most cards in hand.

The player with the highest score wins!

In case of a tie, the player with the most ants in the Meadow wins. If still tied, all tied players share the victory!



2-Player Rules

For a 2-player game of *March of the Ants,* follow these additional rules.

Additional Setup

After completing the normal setup, take these extra steps:

1. Beginning with the Active Player, each player takes 2 of the unused starting hexes at random. Each player chooses 1 hex and places it connected to the Great Tunnel. Return the unchosen hex to the game box.
2. Each player places 3 ants into their placed hex.
3. Set aside the ants and Strength Marker of an unused color for the Old Guard.

Worker Phase

At the start of each Worker Phase, reveal 1 additional Rest Tiles. You'll use 3 Rest Tiles each round–the Great Defender Tile, and two additional ones.

Great Tunnel Battle

At the start of each Soldier Phase, place Old Guard ants equal to the round number into the Great Tunnel.

The Old Guard represents the last remnants of the ancient colony that lived in the Great Tunnel. Their ants cannot be moved or interacted with in any way.

The Old Guard will participate in the Great Tunnel battle as if they were a player. After both players choose to play cards for Ferocity, the Old Guard will discard the top card of the deck and add the Ferocity value to its Strength.

Players always win ties against the Old Guard.

The Old Guard deals and suffers casualties as if it were a normal player (seated to the left of the defender).

The Old Guard will "claim spoils" from the Great Tunnel if they achieve 1st or 2nd. They gain no resources, but will prevent players from gaining those spoils.

Advanced Variants

We highly recommend playing without the advanced modes for your first few games.

EPIC GAME

The epic game of *March of the Ants* is played over 5 rounds rather than 4. It follows all the standard rules of the game with a few adjustments.

The Epic game adds about 10 minutes per player to the game length. In addition, the extra round gives colonies a chance to develop into larger, more complex engines.

Players should have experience with the base game, a good understanding of the economy and how to feed their ants, and be familiar with the different ways to score points.

- During setup, flip the Score Track to the 5-round side and add 1 additional "III+" Reward Tile to the bottom of the stack.
- In Rounds 4 and 5, each food feeds up to 3 ants per food instead of 4 (before adding abdomen bonuses).



ANCIENT SPECIES

Ancient Species is an advanced play variant that allows you to begin the game with unique abilities, drawbacks, and scoring conditions. Each Ancient Species encourages certain styles of play and rewards you for utilizing its powers.

This variant adds about 10-15 minutes per player to the game length. It also adds considerable complexity, extra unpredictability, and big power swings to the game.

Players will need an excellent understanding of the base game rules, round structure, and resource management to succeed using Ancient Species.

Setup

Randomly assign a Nest Mat to each player. Each player plays as the Ancient Species found on the backside of the Nest Mat.

Gameplay

The game follows the standard rules and structure. Each Ancient Species shows the new rules that apply to it.

UNIQUE ACTIONS – Each Ancient Species has a unique action you can use **once per Worker Phase**. These actions give a **Global Reaction**, meaning that all other players, not just the neighboring players, get to take the reaction.

At the start of each Worker Phase, place your Strength Marker in the circular space above your unique action to track whether you have used it. Return it to the Strength Track when you use your unique action, or at the start of the Soldier Phase.

FEATURES – Features are other abilities or penalties that apply to the species. Each Ancient Species has a drawback, and some have a special way to score points during Slumber.

Unique Action Clarifications

Egg Gardeners

Reaction: Choose one of the played Evolution cards and gain larvae equal to its cost. If no evolutions are played for reactions, you do not gain any larvae.

If an ability lets you play more than one Ferocity card, you will lose a point for each.

You do not lose 👑 for playing cards for Ferocity in the Great Tunnel Battle.

Horizon Seekers

Expand counts as a single Explore action for purposes of cards or other effects. Abilities that trigger off of Explore actions (Harvesting or Pollinator Thorax) only apply to one of the explored hexes. If you place both hexes, they must be connected to the same hex and you must move at least 1 ant into each of them.

Visionary Queen

You may have any number of Colony Goals in play but once you have 2 or more, you may only add additional Colony Goals by using your unique action. If you play a Colony Goal in any other way, you must replace one of your current ones.

The additional cost to Evolve multiple times is always 1 ant or larvae, regardless of the cost requirement of the card you are playing.

Chaos Dancers

You must take the steps before resolving the card effect.

Card, Hex, and Rules Clarifications

CARD & HEX CLARIFICATIONS

Event Cards

ADAPTIVE RADIATION – If this card causes you to lose and then complete an ant body you do not lose points or score points as a result.

INTO THE UNKNOWN – There may only be one wormhole per hex. There may only be 1 centipede per hex.

MATING FLIGHT – You may choose to exchange the location of any player's ant, including your own, with that of any other player's ant.

SNEAK ATTACK – This card will not cause a hex battle to take place in round 1. Battle in the hex resolves as it normally would in the Soldier Phase, at which point the Worker Phase continues. If there is a centipede in the hex, it will battle until it is defeated, then, if the hex is still contested, resolve one ant battle.

Evolution Cards

AMAZON HEAD – You gain a larva even if no opponents have larva to lose.

ARMORED HEAD – This does not prevent your last ant in a hex from being lost, as long as enough casualties are assigned to you. This does not prevent you from losing all your ants when you lose to a centipede.

ARMY HEAD – You may move 1 larva from your Larvae Chamber or 1 ant from an adjacent location into the current battle.

BETRAYER ABDOMEN/TRAITOROUS HEAD – Instead of battling a centipede in a hex you are in, you may choose to lose 1 ant from that hex. If you do, other players in that hex still battle the centipede.

BLASTING HEAD – When ants are removed, the player whose ants are removed decides which ants are lost. If this card's effect causes a hex to become uncontested, no battle will take place there. You cannot choose to remove less than  ants, even if it means removing your own. This may be used in Round 1.

FLYING THORAX – This does not allow you to move larvae to hexes you do not inhabit or place an explored hex with no connecting tunnels.

GARDEN THORAX – The cost of cards cannot be reduced to zero.

GOLDEN FIRE HEAD – You must choose to use this ability immediately after you play your standard Ferocity card.

MARCHING THORAX – This does not double March reactions when taken as a Thorax bonus reaction.

PARASITIC THORAX – If 2 or more opponents have an equal amount of larvae, steal 1 larva from each of them.

Steal means the opponent loses 1 larva and you gain 1.

RENEGADE THORAX – Centipedes may not end their movement in the Great Tunnel or a hex with another centipede.

SCOUTING THORAX – You do not need to show the unexplored hex to other players.

TUNNELING THORAX – You cannot place an explored hex with no connecting tunnels. Because you always inhabit hexes with wormholes, you may move larvae directly to those hexes with Explore reactions or with 1 step.

WEAVER THORAX – Your opponents cannot use any actions or card effects to move ants out of hexes you control, including effects that would move your ants. This includes effects that exchange ants. They may use ants in those hexes to pay for the cost of cards.

Colony Goal Cards

EXTENSIVE TUNNEL – "Hexes connected by a single tunnel" refers to a group of hexes that an ant could traverse without retracing its steps.

EYELESS OVERLORDS – There may only be 1 wormhole per hex.

Beyond the Meadow Hexes

ABANDONED SPIDER'S LAIR – The player who places this hex may choose not to play any of the revealed cards.

ANT LION DEN – Only discard cards for inhabited sites, not for the total number of ants in the hex.

NEST OF CENTIPEDES – There can only be 1 centipede in each hex at any time. If all connected hexes already contain a centipede token, no centipede token is placed.

GENERAL RULES CLARIFICATIONS

ACTIVE PLAYER – The player with the Active Player Marker.

CENTIPEDES – A hex can only have 1 centipede token on it at a time. Centipedes may not be placed in the Great Tunnel.

CONTESTED HEX – If multiple players have ants in the same hex and there are ants in the outskirts, it is contested. If a centipede and ants are in the same hex, it is contested. If a hex is contested during Soldier Phase, a battle takes place there.

CONTROL SITE – A site in a hex that gives the occupying ant's player control over that hex, allowing them to win ties in battle and gain 1 point in Slumber if the hex is adjacent to the Great Tunnel.

EXCESS CASUALTIES – Once all casualties have been assigned, any extra have no effect.

GREAT DEFENDER REST TILE – This Rest Tile is available each round. The player with this tile counts as the defender in the Great Tunnel Battle, even if they are not present in the battle. Ties are broken in clockwise order, starting with them, and Ferocity card play starts with the player to their left.

THE GREAT TUNNEL – The central location of the Meadow. You may always move larvae into the Great Tunnel. A battle will take place there during Soldier Phase if ants from 2 or more different colonies are present. The Great Tunnel is not a hex.

HAND – A player's cards. There is no hand size limit. The number of cards each player has is public knowledge.

HEX BATTLE – A battle that takes place in a hex. (As opposed to the Great Tunnel Battle, which is not a hex battle.)

INHABIT – A hex is inhabited by each player who has at least one ant in a collection site in that hex.

THE MEADOW – Consists of the Great Tunnel and all placed hexes.

MOVING LARVAE – When a larva moves to the Meadow, it immediately becomes an ant. When taking steps, you may move larva directly to any hex you inhabit or the Great Tunnel.

LOCATION – Each hex and the Great Tunnel.

LOSE ANTS – Remove your own ants from the Meadow. When you are instructed to lose ants, as a result of a card effect or battle casualties, you choose which ants to lose.

OUTER MEADOW HEX – A hex that is not adjacent to the Great Tunnel.

OUTSKIRTS – Any place in a hex that is not a collection site. If all collection sites in a hex are inhabited, any ant that enters that hex is placed in the outskirts. Ants in the outskirts of a hex automatically move to inhabit collection sites that become empty as soon as the current action or reaction is resolved.

PLAYER ORDER – The order in which turns are taken. Player order is clockwise and starts with the Active Player unless specified otherwise.

PLAY PRIORITY – Unless specified, resolve questions of priority in player order.

REACTIONS – Players only take reactions to their neighbors' main action that they take on their turn. Players do not take reactions to action-like effects that result from cards or other abilities.

SHARED HEX – A hex that 2 or more players inhabit.

WORMHOLE HEX – A hex that contains a wormhole token is sometimes referred to as a wormhole hex.

WORMHOLES – A location with a wormhole token has a wormhole. Ants may move from any hex with a wormhole to any other hex with a wormhole with 1 step. Ants may not Explore through wormholes.

A Note On Scientific Names

The scientific names shown on the Evolution cards include a real life genus and a fictional species. The attributes and characteristics of each ant genus were used as creative inspiration for the Evolution abilities.



Icon Guide

Hex Icons

- CONTROL SITE
- COLLECTION SITE
- FOOD
- COLONY POINT
- SINGLE LARVA
- ANT CARD
- DOUBLE LARVAE
- TUNNEL
- WORMHOLE
- CENTIPEDE

Segment Bonuses

For each head, gain +1 Strength in battle.

At the end of the Worker Phase, choose 1 different reaction per thorax.

Each food feeds 1 additional ant per abdomen.

Worker Phase Actions

EXPLORE – Add a new hex to the Meadow. You may move ants from adjacent connected locations into it (you must move at least 1 ant).
Reaction: Move a larva into the Meadow.

FORAGE – Draw 3 cards, then discard a card from your hand.
Reaction: Gain a larva.

MARCH – Move your larvae to the Meadow and your ants around the Meadow using steps.
Reaction: Take 1 ant step or move a larva to the Great Tunnel.

PLAY A CARD – Pay the cost for a card in your hand to play it.
Reaction: Discard a card from your hand to draw a new card.

REST – Conclude your other actions for the round and begin taking Rest Tiles.
You may not Rest on your first turn in a round.
Reaction: None.

Rest Tiles

Immediate Effects

Place 1 egg in the Great Tunnel.
Take it from your supply, not from your Larvae Chamber.

Take the indicated number of **ant steps.**

You may lose 1 ant to gain the indicated reward.

Gain the indicated resource(s).

Other Effects

Great Defender Tile: You are the defender in the Great Tunnel.
Available each round.

You have +1 Ferocity in all battles this round.

2 of your ants do not need to be fed this round. *They are considered fed.*

Card Icons

The Ferocity number. Used when played in battle, and when resolving some card effects.

Immediate effect when played.

Effect that takes place during Slumber.

Head Thorax Abdomen

Great Tunnel Rules

- The Great Tunnel does not count as a hex.
- Hexes adjacent to the Great Tunnel grant 1 to their controller during Slumber.
- When moving larvae, players may always move them to the Great Tunnel.